Week 12

Chapter 19: Reference and Deixis

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REFERENCE

One of the most basic things that we do when we communicate through language is to pick out entities in the world and ascribe properties to them, or indicate relations between them.

Reference is concerned with designating entities in the world by linguistic means.

- Right at the start we encounter **deep controversies**. One of these concerns is the basic nature of reference
- '*Bill Clinton* (in, say, *Bill Clinton is to visit Ireland in May)* refers to one of presidents of the United States.'
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- '*Bill Clinton* (in, say, *Bill Clinton is to visit Ireland in May)* refers to one of presidents of the United States.'
- Here we are putting forward an **expression** and a **person**, as the terms of the relation of reference.
- However, **there is no privileged one-to-one relationship** between the **expression** *Bill Clinton* and the Bill Clinton who is **president** of the USA.
- There are doubtless **hundreds (at least) of Bill Clintons in the world**.

Bill Clinton **referred** to the **president** of the USA only **because** some **speaker intended** to use the expression **for that purpose** on some particular occasion.

Here we have a unique one-to-one relation, namely, that between the **speaker's intention** to refer and the **president** of the USA.

We shall therefore adopt Searle's (1969) position, and say that:

reference is **not** an inherent property of expressions, but is a **speech act**.

THREE TYPES OF REFERENCE

Types of reference:

1. Definite
2. Indefinite
3. Generic

Definite Reference

- To open the discussion of definite reference, consider the two sentences

below:

(1) The man gave it to her.

(2) A man gave it to her.

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Definite Reference

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Indefinite Reference

(2) A man gave it to her.

- **The features which distinguish (1) from (2)** can be set out as follows:

- The most crucial for the functioning of language.

a. The **intended referential target (*the man*)**is necessarily a **particular entity**

–(This means that the speaker should be able, on demand, to give information that for them distinguishes the (man) in question from all other men.)

b. The speaker intends that the **referential target** should be uniquely **identified for the hearer**, too.

c. The act of reference brings an **implicit assurance the hearer has enough information** to identify the **referent.**

d. Normal input and output conditions hold (speak same language)

e. The **act of reference** is **embedded** in a more inclusive **speech act**.

–(*the man* communicates nothing, except when embedded in a sentence like *I saw the man*)

f. **The speaker intends** that the **hearer should recognize his intention** to refer by virtue of his having produced the utterance in question.

g. The part of the **utterance** the production of which is intended to signal the intention to refer, should have a form which conventionally **performs this function**.

- Identification of the referents of definite referring expressions is necessary so that the hearer can reconstruct the proposition being expressed by the speaker

Indefinite Reference

- The identity of the referent is **not germane** (relevant) to the message.

A man gave it to her.

(قابلتوجه الفي السوق)

- Only the class features indicated are presented as relevant. (Knowing that I met *a man* is enough)

- **Other ways to express indefiniteness:**
- We have so far only considered the **indefinite article** as a signal of indefiniteness.

*(**A** man gave it to her)*

- However, all the following sentences contain indefinite expressions:

1. *Come up and see me sometime.*
2. *I expect he's hiding somewhere.*
3. *You'll manage somehow.*
4. *Are you looking for something/somebody?*

- **Specific/Nonspecific**

Consider now the following sentence:

(3) *To get the automatic door to open, you have to say* ***a word.***

This can be interpreted in two ways:

1. either it is the case that **any word** will open the door,
2. or **a specific** one is necessary.

This is the classic **specific/nonspecific** distinction in indefinites, which has given rise to much discussion

Generic Reference

- Reference to a class of referents
- **Two sorts of proposition** involving generic reference as argument:
  1. Collective reading- something is predicated of the **whole class** referred to

     The tiger is a friendly beast.
  2. Distributed reading- something is predicated of **each member of the class**

     A tiger is a friendly beast.
- The form Xs will accept either use (collective or distributed re

(34) Tigers are extinct.
(35) Tigers are widely distributed.
(36) I like watching tigers.
(37) Tigers have long tails.

Non-referential uses of referring expressions

Although the expression *a tiger* in many of its uses can be used in the act of **indefinite** reference, it is not always so used.

E.g.

*This animal is **a tiger***

a tiger here stands for a set of properties which are being predicted of this animal.

DEIXIS

Any **expression** which located a referent in **space** or **time** was **a deictic expression.**

The term **deixis** refers to cases where the **referent** is **located** using the current **speech event** or one or more of its participants as **reference points**.

e.g. The cat sat on the mat

the cat is **located** with respect to ***the mat***: ***the mat*** is thus the **reference point**, and the speech event plays no role.

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the cat is **located** with respect to ***the mat***: ***the mat*** is thus the **reference point**, and the speech event plays no role.

- In the sentence ***That cat sat on the mat***, however, ***the cat*** is located not only with respect to ***the mat***, but also with respect to **the speaker**, ***that*** indicating (probably) that the cat was relatively distant from the speaker

ive main types of deixis:

1. **person deixis-**involves the **speaker**, the **addressee**, and other **significant participants** in the speech situation (*I, You, he, she…*)
2. **spatial deixis-** manifests itself principally in the form of **locative** adverbs and demonstrative/determiners (*here, there, this, that)*.
3. **temporal deixis-**function to locate points or intervals on the **time** axis using the moment of utterance as a reference point ***(****now, then****)***
4. **social deixis-**exemplified by certain uses of the so-called *TV (tu/vous)* pronouns in many languages
5. **discourse deixis-**refers to such matters as the use of **this to point to future discourse** elements (this), and that to point to past discourse elements (that)

Person Deixis

Person deixis involves basically **the speaker**, known as the **first person,** the **addressee**, known as the **second person,** and other **significant participants** in the speech situation, neither speaker nor hearer; these are known as **third person**

the speaker

addressee

other significant participants

	Singular	Plural
1st person	I/me	we/us
2nd person	you	you
3rd person	he/him, she/her, it	they/them

The representative vs. true use of the plural pronouns:

- The word ***we*** is rarely spoken by a plurality of persons: there is normally

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Representative use is **possible**, but is more **uncommon**

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- In the **second person (*you*)**, the **two possibilities**, of **representative** and **true use**, are more or less equally likely.

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Spatial Deixis

- Include **locative** adverbs such as ***here*** and ***there***, and demonstratives/ determiners such as ***this*** and ***that***.

- English has a relatively impoverished spatial deictic system, with only two terms, usually labelled **proximal (here)** and **distal (there)**

- Some languages have three-term system, **proximal /distal/ remote** distinction. (English at one time had such a system, with three terms *here, there,* and *yonder.)*

Temporal Deixis

Temporal deictics function to locate points or intervals on the **time** axis, using (ultimately) the **moment of utterance** as a reference point.

There are thus three major divisions of the time axis:

(i) before the moment of utterance (past)

(ii) at the time of utterance (present)

(iii) after the time of utterance. (Future)

- **The most basic temporal deictics** in English are ***now*** and ***then***
- ***Now*** is in some ways a kind of temporal *here (Press the button—**Now**)*
- ***Then*** points away from the present (*OK, I'll see you **then**)*
- (*today, yesterday, tomorrow, this/last/next +*

Social Deixis

Social deixis is exemplified by certain uses of the so-called TV ***(tu / vous)*** pronouns in many languages.

The choice is usually described by some such term as **'social distance**'

tu indicates intimacy

vous Indicates lack of intimacy, or distance.

Arabic uses the singular and the plural to express social distance. How?

1. نتمنى منكم التكرم بمساعدتنا
2. اتمنى منك التكرم بمساعدتي

Which is more formal?

Discourse Deixis

Discourse deixis refers to:

- the use of ***this*** to point to future discourse elements, that is, things which are about to be said as in:

*Listen to **this**, it will kill you!*

- The use of ***that*** to point to past discourse elements,

as in:

***That** was not a very nice thing to say.*

- *(hereby, therefore, furthermore)*

Psychological use of spatial deixis

- It may be presumed that spatial deixis is the prototypical variety, and is certainly the source for much metaphoric generalization.
- A relatively simple extension is into what Langacker calls **'abstract space**'. This is exemplified by such usages as:

Here *the* ***argument*** *runs into difficulties*

What do you think of ***this idea*** *of mine/* ***that idea*** *of George's?*

- **Ideas** and **arguments** do not literally occupy space, but it is easy to think of them as if they did.

Gestural and symbolic deixis

- Some uses of deictics require for their interpretation continuous **monitoring of relevant aspects of the speech situation**: in the clearest cases, **the hearer has to be able to see the speaker and their gestures**:

  - Put one over there and the other one here.
  - This is the finger that hurts, not that one.
  - Press the button when I give the word — *now!*
  - I want three volunteers: you, you, and you.

Gestural deixis

Gestural and symbolic deixis

- In other cases, such minute **monitoring of the speech situation** is **not necessary**, and the relevant parameters for the deictic interpretation are established over relatively long period of conversation/discourse. This is called **symbolic deixis**

  - Isn't it interesting? (people at an exhibition)
  - Isn't this weather amazing?

symbolic deixis

References

Cruse, A. (2011). *Meaning in language: An introduction to semantics and pragmatics.* Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Thank you